Mr. C's History Hijack

presents

MARE NOSTRUM

A History Simulation Game

Eastern Mediterranean, 350 BC

Complete Rules, Version 1.0

For 8 players per group · Turns represent 15 game-years · One semester of play

The eight powers of the ancient Mediterranean compete for territory, trade, and survival across 120 years of history — from the height of Greek civilization to the shadow of Macedonian conquest. Military strength alone will not win. Control the trade nodes. Master the sea lanes. Outmaneuver your rivals in the council chamber as much as on the battlefield.

Section 1 — The Game

1.1 Overview

Mare Nostrum is a turn-based strategy game played on a map of the eastern Mediterranean circa 350 BC. Eight players each control one historical power. The game combines territorial conquest (adapted from the board game Diplomacy), commercial strategy (through Caravans and trade nodes), and historical research (which unlocks in-game capabilities). Each game-turn represents **15 years** of historical time. One semester of play covers eight turns, moving from 350 BC to approximately 245 BC.

1.2 The Eight Powers

Athens (Green)	Dominant naval and commercial power. Controls Piraeus. Grain-route dependent.
Sparta (Blue)	Dominant Greek land power. Strongest infantry. No natural trade focus.
Macedon (White)	Rising northern power. Philip II's army reforms are your research prize.
Satraps (Orange)	Recent revolt attempts to take power in Trojan territory
Persia (Brown)	Largest power on the board. Wealthy but overextended. Controls Egypt.
Phoenicia (Purple)	Commercial powerhouse. Two fleets, rich trade nodes, limited land territory.
Carthage (Yellow)	Western Mediterranean anchor. Controls Sicily trade. Navy-focused.
Rome (Red)	Weakest starting position. Highest growth potential. Patience rewarded.

Note: In the seven-power game, Sparta is a non-player, with its elite Hoplite unit stationary but with a defense power of 3 (can only be dislodged by 4). In the six-player game, Rome is also a non-player, with three armies—Rome, Neapolis, and Ravenna. All Roman units will mutually support, but will not move. They may be dislodged by an attack power of 3 (see Section 5—Combat)

1.3 Winning

There is no single victory condition. At the end of each semester, Mr. C scores each power on three tracks:

- **Territory** — number of supply centers held at game end.
- **Wealth** — total economic points accumulated over all turns.
- **Research** — cumulative research score across all turns.

Each track produces a ranking. The player whose combined rank is highest wins. This structure means a pure military player, a pure trade player, and a balanced player all have a plausible path to winning — as in history.

Section 2 — The Map

2.1 Territories

The map is divided into named territories. Every territory is either a

land territory — controlled by armies — or a **sea zone** — controlled by fleets. Coastal territories may be controlled by either kind of military unit. Land territories may contain supply centers, trade nodes, or both, or neither.

2.2 Supply Centers

Supply centers are marked on the map with a filled circle. They are the source of new military units.

> **Rule:** Each supply center you control at the end of a turn allows you to maintain one army or one fleet. If you have more units than supply centers, you must disband units (your choice which) until the numbers match.
>
> **Rule:** Supply centers are captured by moving a unit into the territory containing them. You capture a supply center at the end of the turn — not during movement.
>
> **Rule:** Additional units may be supported by economic power (see 3.3). This may result in a power having more units than supply centers.

2.3 Trade Nodes

Trade nodes are marked with a gold star (★). They are the source of economic points.

Piraeus (Athens)	1 Eco/turn — Athens' great harbor. Aegean chokepoint.
Corinth	1 Eco/turn — Controls isthmus and both sea approaches.
Byzantium	2 Eco/turn — The Hellespont. All Black Sea grain passes here.
Media	1 Eco/turn — Western end of the Persian Royal Road.
Cyprus	1 Eco/turn — Eastern Mediterranean crossroads.
Jerusalem	2 Eco/turn — The great Phoenician double-city.
Naucratis (Alexandria)	1 Eco/turn — Egypt's Greek trading port. Grain exporter.
Carthage	1 Eco/turn — Western Mediterranean hub.
Sicilia	1 Eco/turn — Central port for east/west/north/south trade

> **Rule:** A Caravan present at a trade node (elsewhere than at a player's home center) at the end of a turn generates the listed economic points for its owner. A Caravan in transit generates nothing that turn.

2.4 Sea Zones

The map contains five sea zones: the Adriatic Sea, the Ionian Sea, the Aegean Sea, the Eastern Mediterranean, and the Western Mediterranean (between Carthage and Sicily). Fleets and Caravans move through sea zones. Armies do not enter sea zones unless transported by fleet.

Section 3 — Units

3.1 The Three Unit Types

Each power fields up to three types of units. All units occupy one territory or sea zone at a time.

Armies (A)

Armies move on land. They conquer land territories and supply centers. They cannot enter sea zones unless transported.

Rule: An army may move to any adjacent land territory each turn.

Rule: An army may be transported across a sea zone by a friendly fleet occupying that zone, moving to any coastal territory on the far side. The fleet must remain in the sea zone (it does not move during a transport turn).

Fleets (F)

Fleets move at sea and along coastlines. They protect trade routes, blockade enemy trade, and transport armies.

Rule: A fleet may move to any adjacent sea zone or coastal territory each turn.

Rule: A fleet in a sea zone or coastal territory can transport one army across that zone per turn (see above).

Caravans (C)

Caravans are Caravans—merchant convoys, explorers, or trading expeditions. They move along designated trade routes — not freely across the map.

Rule: A Caravan may move one step along a trade route per turn. Trade routes are the gold dashed lines on the map.

Rule: A Caravan at a trade node at turn's end generates full income for its owner.

Rule (Inactive for this round): A Caravan can be blockaded but not destroyed by a military unit. A hostile army or fleet in the same territory as a Caravan prevents it from generating income that turn, but the Caravan remains.

Rule (Inactive for this round): A Caravan can only be permanently destroyed by a hostile Caravan in the same territory (privateering/piracy) — both units are eliminated. The eliminating player gains 1 economic point.

3.2 Elite Units

Some units may be upgraded to **elite** status through research. Elite units are marked with special shading around the unit. They are considered to have a power of 2 units, except as noted below.

Rule: An elite army requires three standard unit power to dislodge from a territory (see Section 5, Combat). Two units' power cannot remove an elite army, no matter the attack or support — the attack bounces.

Rule: In attack, an elite unit carries the power of two regular units.

Rule: In support, an elite unit carries the power of two regular units EXCEPT that support may be cut with a single attack. If an elite unit is supporting another unit, and the elite unit is attacked, its support is CUT (not simply diminished) as if it were a regular unit.

Rule: Elite status is permanent until the unit is eliminated.

Rule: A power may have at most two elite units at any time.

Rule: Upgrade of military units to Elite status requires 8 resource points (see Quick Reference) and may be made on build phase (Wednesdays). Caravans may not be upgraded.

Note on the Spartan Hoplites: Sparta begins the game with one elite army representing the Hoplites. This is the only starting elite unit in the game.

3.3 Building New Units

New units are built between turns, after research bonuses and policy effects are applied.

Rule: An army costs 6 economic points or one supply center to build. It is placed in any home supply center you control.

Rule: A fleet costs 6 economic points or one supply center to build. It is placed in any coastal home supply center you control.

Rule: A Caravan costs 4 economic points to build. It is placed at any trade node you currently occupy or at your home supply center.

Rule: Any military unit may be built to bring the number of units into equality with supply centers owned, no matter the economic points a power possesses.

Rule: With economic power, you **may** build more units than you have supply centers to support (see 2.2).

3.4 Economic Point Banking

Economic points are tracked in Mr. C ledger and do not expire unless you exceed the banking cap.

Rule: A power may bank a maximum of 15 economic points between turns. Points above 15 are lost. Spend or build — hoarding has a ceiling.

Section 4 — Turn Structure

Each turn represents 10 years of game time. The game begins in 350 BC. One game will last 7 weeks, or about 70 years (one turn per week), ending approximately 280 BC.

Phase 1	Thursday 11pm	Research submission
Phase 2	Friday	GM scores research, applies bonuses
Phase 3		Diplomacy (negotiation period)
Phase 4	Monday 11pm	Orders written and submitted simultaneously
Phase 5	Tuesday	GM adjudicates all orders
Phase 6	Tuesday	Results announced; map updated; economic income collected
Phase 7	Wednesday Noon	Retreat phase (if any) — players move any dislodged units
Phase 7	Wednesday 11pm	Build phase — players spend economic points/build/destroy units
Phase 8	Thursday Morning	Results announced, map updated

4.1 Phase 1 — Research Submission

Before every other turn (one submission per week), each player submits research on their assigned topic. Research topics are specific to each power's historical situation in the relevant time period.

- Research is submitted via email before the deadline (see website).
- Topics are typed — Military, Economic, or Diplomatic — matching the resource bonus they unlock.
- Research is scored 0–100 by Mr. C.

4.2 Phase 2 — Research Scoring

Score 90–100	+3 points of the matching resource type
Score 75–89	+2 points of the matching resource type
Score 50–74	+1 point of the matching resource type
Score below 50 or missing	+0 points. The historical record is silent on your behalf.

Example: Athens submits research on the grain route through the Hellespont (Economic topic) and scores 88. Athens receives +2 Economic points this turn.

4.3 Phase 3 — Domestic Policy (Inactive in this game—disregard)

Each player chooses one domestic policy for the turn. Choices are submitted to Mr. C before diplomacy begins. Options are specific to each power and change each turn based on historical conditions.

Policy effects are applied immediately. A typical policy choice looks like this:

- **Invest in the military** → +3 Military, −1 Economic (must have an economic point to expend)
- **Fund merchant guilds** → +3 Economic, −1 Military (must have a military point to expend)

Other policy decisions may be made, but they will fall into either military or economic categories and will be rewarded/penalized as above.

4.4 Phase 4 — Diplomacy

This is the heart of the game. Players negotiate openly, make promises, form alliances, and plan betrayals. Diplomacy is conducted in class during the designated period.

> **Rule:** No agreement is binding. Alliances, non-aggression pacts, and trade agreements are promises only. Breaking them has no mechanical penalty — but your classmates will remember.
>
> **Rule:** Diplomatic communication never ends. All phases include diplomatic components.

On secrecy and honesty: You may lie about your intentions. All moves, however, will be revealed. Pre-move negotiation is political; submitted orders are actual.

4.5 Phase 5 — Orders

Each player writes orders for each of their units and submits them to Mr. C simultaneously. Orders are secret until adjudication.

Each unit receives exactly one order. Valid orders:

- **Move:** Unit moves to an adjacent territory or sea zone. Example: Fleet Piraeus → Aegean Sea
- **Support:** Unit supports an adjacent unit's move or hold. Example: Army Athens supports Army Corinth → Sparta
- **Hold:** Unit stays in place. Example: Army Thebes holds
- **Transport:** Fleet transports an army across a sea zone. Example: Fleet Ionian transports Army Sparta → Corinth
- **Trade:** Caravan moves one step along a trade route. Example: Caravan Corinth → Piraeus

Critically important: move orders must be submitted correctly or the moves are invalid. Invalid moves will be interpreted as the unit holding position. One invalid move does not invalidate the other moves submitted by the power.

4.6 Phase 6 — Adjudication

Mr. C adjudicates all orders simultaneously according to the combat rules in Section 5. Results are announced publicly.

4.7 Phase 7 — Income

After adjudication, economic income is collected.

- Each Caravan at a trade node generates that node's full income for its owner.
- Each military unit at a trade node generates half that node's income (rounded down).
- Income is recorded in Mr. C ledger and added to each player's economic point total.

4.8 Phase 8 — Building

Players may spend economic points to build new units or upgrade existing ones.

Army	6 resource points
Fleet	6 resource points
Caravan	4 resource points
Elite upgrade	8 resource points (max 2)
Banking cap	15 resource points max

Section 5 — Combat

Combat in Mare Nostrum follows the same fundamental logic as the board game Diplomacy: there are no dice. Outcomes are determined entirely by force of numbers and supporting orders. This means that a clever defensive coalition can hold against a superior power, and betrayal can be more decisive than battle.

5.1 The Basic Rule

Rule: A unit moving into a territory occupied by a hostile unit dislodges that unit only if its total attacking force (the unit plus any supporting units) is strictly greater than the defending force (the defending unit plus any supporting units). Equal forces result in a bounce — neither unit moves.

Example: *Army Macedon moves to Thrace (supported by Fleet Macedon). Attacking force = 2. Army Persia holds in Thrace (no support). Defending force = 1. Macedon wins — the Persian army is dislodged.*

Example: *Army Athens moves to Corinth (no support). Army Sparta holds in Corinth (supported by Army Peloponnese). Attacking force = 1. Defending force = 2. Sparta holds.*

5.2 Support

A unit may support an adjacent unit's move or hold instead of moving itself.

Rule: Support is cut if the supporting unit is itself attacked from any direction other than the territory it is supporting into.

Example: *Army Thebes supports Army Athens moving to Corinth. If Army Sparta attacks Thebes from Corinth (the direction Thebes is supporting into), support is NOT cut. If Army Sparta attacks Thebes from Sparta, support IS cut.*

5.3 Dislodgement and Retreat

Rule: A dislodged unit must retreat to an adjacent territory that is not occupied and was not the territory from which the attacking force came.

Rule: If no valid retreat exists, the unit is eliminated.

Rule: A retreating unit does not generate income that turn.

5.4 Fortified Supply Centers

A player may spend 3 economic points during the building phase to fortify a supply center.

Rule: A fortified supply center gives the defending unit in that territory a +1 bonus to its defense force. This stacks with support.

Rule: Fortification is permanent but applies only to units defending from within the fortified territory.

Rule: A supply center loses its fortification if captured.

5.5 Elite Units in Combat

Rule: An elite unit counts as force 2 rather than force 1 when attacked. That is, dislodging an elite unit from a territory requires an attacking force of 3 or more (attacking force plus two uncut supports).

Rule: An elite unit's own attack also counts as force 2.

Rule: Elite units support with force 2. Elite units may support other units to hold or to attack, just as a regular unit, only their power is doubled. **But elite units are subject to the same rules as regular units when attacked while supporting**, that is, their support is CUT, not diminished.

5.6 Naval Combat

Fleet-on-fleet combat follows identical rules to land combat. A fleet moving into a sea zone or coastal territory occupied by a hostile fleet must have greater force to dislodge it.

Rule: A fleet blockading a Caravan does not eliminate it — it only prevents income. The Caravan may attempt to move away on the following turn.

5.7 Convoy Interdiction

An army being transported by fleet may be intercepted.

Rule: If the transporting fleet is dislodged during the turn the transport is ordered, the transport fails and the army remains in its original territory. An attack that fails to dislodge the convoying unit also fails to interdict the convoy.

5.8 Elimination

Although unlikely, it is possible for a power to be eliminated—to have all units belonging to that power removed from the map, and to control no territory. This is sad. We will cry big tears for you. You will still have assignments, but you will take no further part in the actual game. Do not let this happen to you.

Section 6 — Research

Research is what makes Mare Nostrum a history class rather than just a game. Each turn you submit a research assignment before each move. The quality of your research determines in part what resources your power can access. Poor research reflects a power operating in historical ignorance; strong research reflects a power that understood its own situation.

6.1 Research Topics

You are responsible for creating topics of research for your power each turn. Topics are specific to your power and the current time period. A topic might be:

- Military — "Describe the composition and tactics of the Macedonian sarissa phalanx under Philip II."
- Economic — "Explain the role of the Phoenician purple dye trade in Mediterranean commerce, 400–350 BC."
- Diplomatic — "What agreements governed Athens' grain supply from the Black Sea, and who enforced them?"

6.2 What Makes Good Research

Mr. C scores research on accuracy, specificity, and depth — not length. A two-paragraph response that demonstrates genuine historical knowledge outscores a two-page response full of vague generalities. Specific names, dates, places, and mechanisms are rewarded. Assertions without evidence are not.

A score of 90+ means: you demonstrated precise historical knowledge that would have been genuinely useful to a leader in your position. Bonus points reflect this as tangible capability.

A score of 50–74 means: you showed basic familiarity but missed important specifics. Your power operates with partial information.

A score below 50 means: your research was too vague, inaccurate, or superficial to be useful. No bonus is earned.

6.3 Research and Upgrades

Certain research achievements unlock special capabilities that cannot be purchased with economic points alone. Mr. C will announce these as they become available. Examples (not necessarily active in your version of the game):

- Research on the Macedonian army reforms (Military, score 85+) unlocks the ability to upgrade one Macedonian army to elite.
- Research on Phoenician navigation techniques (Economic, score 90+) allows Phoenician Caravans to move two steps along a route per turn for one turn.
- Research on the Spartan agoge and krypteia (Military, score 80+) unlocks a fortification bonus for Sparta's home territories.

Note: These unlocks can be cumulative and force/bonus multipliers can be unlocked in mysterious ways—just like in real life. The breadth and depth and (especially) enthusiasm of your research will be your best chance at achieving satisfactory results.

Also Note: you never know what bonuses are available. These upgrades are hidden. Suffice it to say that every NSP has bonuses it can access. It’s up to you to find them.

Section 7 — Starting Positions (350 BC)

Power	Units / Starting Economic Points
Power	**Starting units and economic points**
Athens	1 Army (Athens), 2 Fleets (Rhodes and Crete), 1 Caravan (Athens). 4 Eco points. Supply centers: Rhodes, Athens, Crete).
Sparta	2 Armies (Corinth and Sparta). 2 Eco points. Supply centers: Sparta, Corinth. Military advantage: Elite Unit (Army Sparta).
Macedon	2 Armies (Macedon, Thessaly), 1 Fleet (Thrace). 2 Eco points. Supply centers: Macedon, Thessaly, Thrace.
Satrapies	2 Armies (Galatia, Miletus). 1 Fleet (Bithynia) 1 Caravan (Galatia) 3 Eco points. Supply centers: Bithynia, Galatia, Miletus
Persia	2 Armies (Damascus, Petra), 1 Fleet (Alexandria), 1 Caravan (Damascus). 6 Eco points. Supply centers: Damascus, Petra, Alexandria.
Phoenicia	2 Fleets (Cyprus, Sidon), 1 Army (Tyre), 1 Caravan (Sidon). 5 Eco points. Supply centers: Sidon, Tyre, Cyprus.
Carthage	2 Fleets (Thopsis, Maraka)), 1 Army (Carthage), 1 Caravan (Carthage). 4 Eco points. Supply centers: Carthage, Thopsis, Maraka.
Rome	2 Armies (Rome, Ravenna). 2 Eco points. Supply centers: Rome, Ravenna.

As noted above, in the seven-player version Sparta is a non-player, with an elite army based in Sparta that cannot move but can be dislodged by attack power of 4. In the six-player version, Rome is also a non-player, with 3 armies (Rome, Ravenna, and Neapolis), all of which units will mutually support, and may be dislodged by an attack power of 3.

Section 8 — GM Notes and Adjudication

8.1 The Game Master (GM)

The GM (Mr. C) is the final authority on all rules questions, adjudication disputes, and research scoring. The GM also injects historical events into the game — not as random dice rolls, but as structured situations that reflect real historical pressures. These will be announced at the start of each turn.

8.2 Adjudication Principles

When orders are ambiguous or conflict in unexpected ways, Mr. C applies these principles in order:

- Simultaneous orders: all moves happen at the same time. A unit moving out of a territory does not protect that territory from capture.
- Bounces create a chain reaction: if A bounces B, and B's failure would have allowed C to succeed, C may now succeed (or not) based on the new configuration.
- When in genuine doubt, Mr. C errs toward the outcome that creates the most interesting historical situation.

8.3 Research Scoring Guidance

Mr. C will score research as he would a history research essay (which is what this is): on accuracy of historical fact, appropriate use of primary or secondary evidence, and demonstrated understanding of cause and effect. Students who fabricate historical detail score 0 for that assignment, regardless of how plausible it sounds. The purpose of the research requirement is genuine historical learning, not creative writing. That said, this is the sort of essay you'll write a thousand times in the future. Find something interesting, and tell it to me in as brief and pointed and genuine manner as possible.

8.4 Historical Events

Each turn, Mr. C may announce one or two historical events affecting specific powers. These are not random — they reflect real events from the period and may include:

- Persian satrapal revolts weakening Persia's western control (reduces one Persia army's effectiveness for one turn)
- Athenian grain shortage if the Hellespont route is blocked (−2 Eco to Athens if Byzantium is hostile-held)
- Philip of Macedon's assassination (Turn 5) — triggers a Macedon succession crisis with research opportunities
- Volcanic activity in the eastern Mediterranean—reduces fleet movement for 1 turn

Historical events are designed to reward students who researched the relevant period — if you know the history, you can anticipate and prepare.

8.5 The Reboot

At the end of the quarter (about 7 weeks, or roughly Halloween), the game resets to a new starting position representing the world at another time and place. There is no carryover from one quarter to the next. As tempting as it may be for you to *personally* carry alliances, grudges, etc. from one quarter to the next, *don't.* This is, yes, history, but it is also a game. You will not disqualify yourself as a person of integrity because you lied to your best friend about where your navies were going on turn 3. Make your betrayals worth it, and your domination as complete as you can make it. Then leave it behind—and do it again. Only better this time.

Quick Reference

Turn sequence

1. Research	Submit before deadline
2. GM scoring	Bonuses applied to ledger
3. Policy	Submit domestic choice
4. Diplomacy	In-class negotiation
5. Orders	Written and submitted simultaneously
6. Adjudication	GM resolves all moves
7. Income	Trade nodes pay out
8. Building	Spend economic points

Costs

Army	6 resource points
Fleet	6 resource points
Caravan	4 resource points
Elite upgrade	8 resource points (max 2)
Banking cap	15 resource points max

Research bonuses

Outstanding info/presentation–a truly wise ruler is here	+3 resource points
Solid, interesting info–should lead to advantages	+2 resource points
Basic understanding of the people and land	+1 resource point
Missing/substandard–the history books record nothing	+0

Combat summary

- Move: attacker must have strictly greater force than defender to dislodge.
- Support: adds +1 to attacking or defending force. Cut by attacks from other directions.
- Elite unit: counts as force 2 when defending. Requires force 3+ to dislodge.
- Bounce: equal forces = nobody moves.
- Dislodged unit retreats or is eliminated.

Trade summary

- Caravan at node = full node income.
- Military unit at node = half income (rounded down).
- Caravan blockaded by 1 military unit = 0 income, unit survives.
- Caravan vs. hostile Caravan = both eliminated, attacker gains 1 Eco.